

PICKIN' COTTON

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Awhile back I was driving down the road in an area where cotton is still grown. The fields had recently been picked - you could see the scraps of cotton along the road where they had blown out of the big wagons that carry it to the gin. There were still small pieces stuck to the plants which were drying up out in the fields.

Whenever I see a cotton field I'm always reminded of my one experience at pickin' cotton when I was growing up in southern Oklahoma. This was back in 1931 when all cotton picking was still done by hand. My family lived in a "company town" out in the country and I went to a rural area consolidated school. Every year after school got to goin' good it would come cotton picking time and the whole school would close down so the kids could help their folks bring in the cotton crop. If their family didn't plant cotton, then they were able to work for someone who did. Best as I can remember this took place during two or three weeks in October. The pay as I recall was about two cents per pound. You know how much cotton it takes to make a pound?

Never mind about that. Two of my friends, Buddie Watkins and Sap Ray and I decided we were going to make ourselves

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some of that big money that was going to be changing hands. There was a ~~big~~ carnival coming to Ada, Oklahoma and we wanted to be able to go to it with lots of money in our overalls. Shoot, we might even make as much as five dollars.

We let it be known that we were all three expert pickers (after all, how much did you need to know about reaching out and pulling a wad of cotton away from the bush it grew on?) and were selected and assigned to one of the many cotton patches in the area.

Sap, whose real name was Junior (but nobody, not even his mother, called him that), arranged for his mother to drive us to the farm where we were to pick. We had been told to pack a sack lunch each day. We had also been told to be at the farm by 5 a.m. each morning.

When we headed out it was dark. When we got to the farm it was still dark.

The three of us, along with several other pickers were told to get into an old high-sided wooden wagon which was driven by a big man in faded blue overalls. The wagon was pulled by two gray mules and we rolled out onto a rutted dirt road and started out for the cotton field. Sap and I had managed to get into the driver seat, mainly because Sap said he knew how to use the big hand brake. Before long we wished we hadn't been so eager to sit up front.

Sitting on that front seat put us right behind the back side of those two mules, one of which would break wind right in our faces ever time that farmer would urge them into a trot.

This didn't seem to bother him but it was sure hard for us to take. That ride out to the field took us about half an hour, and believe you me, we were plenty glad to get down on the ground when we had reached our picking area. That ole mule must have been feeding on onion weed.

We were all given a big long white sack to hang over our shoulder. That thing drag out behind you about six feet. I swear, it looked big enough to hold that farmer and six more his same size.

We were told to pick the boll as clean as we could and not to put any leaves or boll husks in the sack. When we had so much cotton that it was getting too heavy to drag then we were supposed to take our sack back to the weighing wagon. Here it would be weighed, the amount marked by our name, and the sack emptied into the big wagon which would haul it to the cotton gin. Then we would start picking again.

We started picking with everyone lined up in their own row. There must have been ten or twelve of us all together. There were some other school kids like us, several negro men and one negro woman, and finally several white men and one or two white women.

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By the time we started picking it was getting light enough to see that we were in one mighty big cotton field. Those rows stretched out for what looked like at least a mile. The rows went down about half way to a slight valley then sloped gently up toward a grove of trees at the far end. Getting to those trees was to become our main goal that day.

We all bent over and began working our own row. There was quite a bit of talk at first among us kids, mostly about the carnival which we all planned to attend. The grown-ups said little, just kept their heads down and kept picking. It didn't take long for us to realize that this way of earning money wasn't going to be a piece of cake.

By about nine o'clock in the morning we felt like we had been working all day. Our shirts were soaked with sweat, so were our overalls. Flies swarmed around our heads, zooming into our ears, and up our nose. Big green flies buzzed us and crawled on our hands and arms. In a word we were miserable. The grown-ups had gotten out ahead of us shortly after we started and by now we didn't concern ourselves about that fact.

All we thought about was making it to the trees and resting in their shade before heading back to the wagon. We unloaded our sacks each time we got to the wagon. Which wasn't very often.

We didn't want to drag that weight any farther than we had to.

Within another hour we were not only miserable, we were starving. It had been over five hours since we had eaten breakfast. The next time we reached the trees we all flopped to the ground in the shade and tore open our sacks and ate our lunches, down to the last sandwich crumb.

Reluctantly, we went back to picking, which I considered by now to be sheer torture.

The sun cooked our bodies. We were constantly thirsty, and the water at the weighing wagon was already warm and helped little when we drank it.

Buddie and Sap poured as much on their heads as they drank. I began to follow their example and it helped some.

At noon time someone at the wagon rang a bell and all the others took their lunches and headed for the grove of trees except for a few who crawled under the wagon to eat. The three of us had nothing left to eat and yet we were hungry again by this time.

We were too embarrassed to ask anyone to share with us so we walked further back into the woods. At ^{least} we could get away from the site and smell of the food which the others were eating.

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About fifty yards back in the trees we found what was to be our salvation. We came upon a small sandy bottom creek which was about waist deep on the three of us. We all took off ~~all~~ our clothes except our undershorts and plunged into the cool water, splashing and hollering. We enjoyed ourselves and were almost beginning to feel normal again when the bell rang signaling us to go back to work.

The rest of that day has always been fuzzy in my memory. They say we subconsciously put unpleasant experiences in the dark recesses of our minds and I'm sure that's what happened. Somehow, some way we managed to finish the day. We quit at five o'clock, turned in our sacks and drew our pay for the day. I don't remember now how much we made, I think it was only two or three dollars apiece.

I do remember we didn't pick anymore cotton after that first day and that we all went to the carnival the next weekend and had a good time on the rides and looking at the man who had three legs. We ate greasy hamburgers, and popcorn. We tried to get a prize with the little iron claw machines.

One thing we didn't do though and that was to eat any cotton candy.